NON-STATE ACTORS IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

John Burton (*The Study of World Society: A London Perspective* (1974), a famous theorist of international relations, opined that for ages there have been several images, models of abstractions to focus on the different aspects of world society. One such image is that of the realist perception of the world. This conventional image projects a vision of the world composed of nation-states, which are of different size and power. This image became popularized as the 'billiard ball' model. These models upheld the presence of sovereign, independent states represented by their governments as units and the interactions or contacts among them are like those of different sized billiard balls, only the hard exteriors touch and heavier or faster moving ones push others out of the way. In other words, the points of contact are government to government. Therefore, this image only focussed on diplomatic relations, on governments as the main actors in world affairs, on their relative power and on the personal characteristics of their leaders. But a sea-change has occurred since the formulation of this image especially since the Second World War. Thus, there was the need to revise this world image.[24] Burton and his colleagues highlighted that with the growth in technology, communication, transportation and weaponry, the classical European model of balance of power model has become inadequate. Further, they neglected the internal processes and components within the states and interactions among various non-state actors such as political parties, ethnic groups and multinational corporations, which have greatly influenced and sometimes manoeuvred governmental decisions.

Therefore, Burton suggested a contrast to the realist model, which he termed as the cobweb model—a pluralist image of the world society. He argues that a cobweb or series of superimposed and intermeshing cobwebs would be in a better position to give an almost accurate image of the world society than a set of billiard balls. Though it would be difficult to theorize but nevertheless it would reflect, with less distortion, the actual political and economic processes that crisscross the globe. The cobweb model, he suggested, would not only take into account the activities of